

Architectural styles

JAPANESE

Japanese architecture is characterized by the consistency of its exteriors—timber construction supporting large gabled roofs—and the flexibility of its interior spaces, which are separated by moveable screens, allowing spaces to change depending on needs.

From 1633 until 1853, the policy of *sakoku* made it illegal for any Japanese person to leave the country and any foreigner to enter. This ensured that up until this point, Japanese architecture—as well as broader culture and society—existed in seclusion, developing in its own way according to its own recurring ideas and underlying principles. Shinto shrines and Buddhist temples became its most recognizable building types.

The result of this centuries-long isolation was the striking consistency of Japanese architecture in both design and materials. Stone is rarely used—only significantly in the bases of some temples and castles—with wood forming the starting point of a post-and-lintel construction method. Walls are not load-bearing and are usually thin, sometimes paper thin. The large gabled roofs are the main focus for architectural display, with ornamentation usually issuing from the structural elements.

With the opening up of Japan to international trade at the end of the 19th century, the native tradition began to be supplemented by Western styles. In the 20th century, Japan embraced Modernism, particularly after World War II, with the internationally significant Metabolist movement, which fused high technology with traditional Japanese architectural principles.

typically ceramic in composition

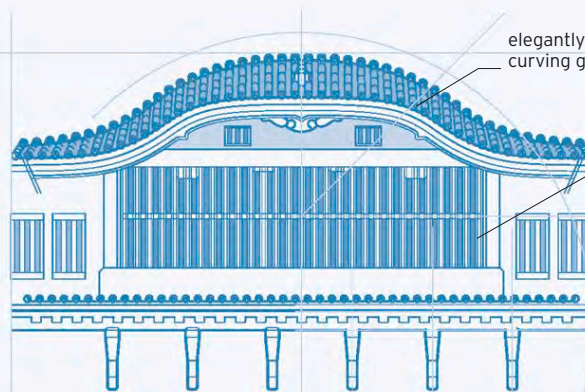
water to extinguish fire believed to be released through mouth

▷ SHACHIHOKO

A *shachihoko* is a mythical Japanese creature fusing the head of a tiger and the tail of a fish. *Shachihoko* ornaments are often found on roofs because they were said to guard against fire.

elegantly curving gable

protective lattice



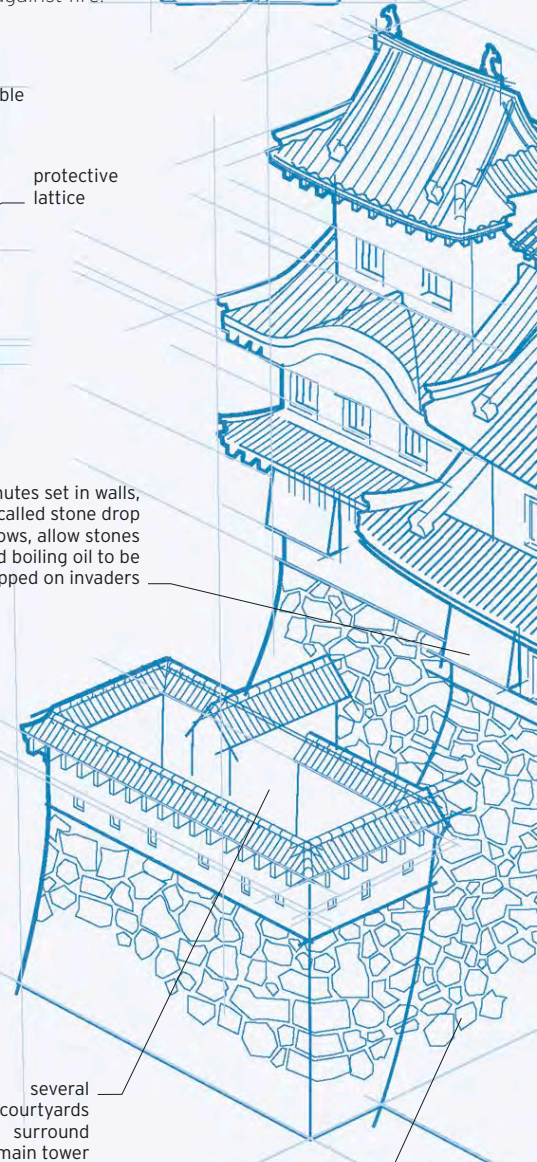
△ LATTICE WINDOWS

Lattice windows appear throughout Japanese architecture, usually in the form of internal *shoji* screens. At Himeji Castle, the latticework is much tighter, reflecting its exposed position and role as a defensive building.

► HIMEJI CASTLE

Himeji Castle (see p.272) is regarded as one of the finest surviving Japanese castles. It comprises a stone base—a rare example of the use of this material in Japanese architecture—and a superstructure of timber tiered roofs.

chutes set in walls, called stone drop windows, allow stones and boiling oil to be dropped on invaders

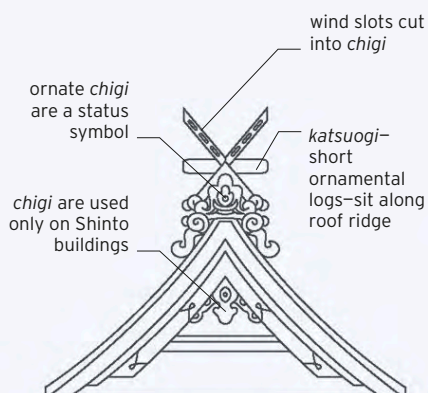


several courtyards surround main tower

traditional *washi* paper

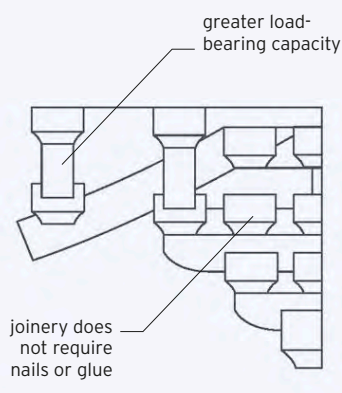
platform of rammed earth faced with dressed-stone slabs

TIMBER AND PAPER STRUCTURES



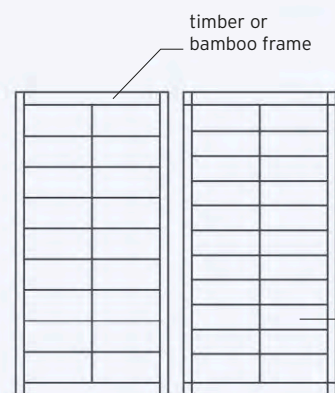
△ CHIGI FINIALS

Chigi are finials of two angled planks of timber projecting from the apex of gable ends of Shinto temples. Some are integrated into the roof structure, while others stand separate.



△ TIMBER JOINTS

Japanese craftsmen developed a distinctive language of woodworking joints with different traditions of carpentry focused on temples, domestic architecture, and interiors.



△ SHOJI SCREENS

Key to Japanese architecture is the division of internal spaces with sliding screens. Usually comprising a timber frame and paper, they allow rooms to be opened and closed.